

Obsidian_Built-in_Tools_for_Genealogists

Obsidian's Built-in Tools for Genealogists

A beginner-friendly guide for the SGS AI Special Interest Group

Obsidian includes many useful features without installing community plugins. Obsidian calls these features **core plugins**.

You can turn core plugins on or off under:

Settings → Core plugins



Start with a few tools that solve an immediate research problem. You do not need to enable or learn everything at once.

Recommended for beginners

File Explorer

File Explorer displays the folders and files in your vault.

Genealogy uses

- Browse People, Families, Places, Sources, and Research Logs.
- Move notes into understandable folders.
- Create new notes and folders.
- See PDFs, images, and other attachments stored in the vault.

Remember that the files shown here are ordinary files stored in a folder on your computer.

Learn online: [Manage notes and files](#)

Search

Search finds words and phrases throughout the notes and canvases in your vault—not only in filenames.

Genealogy uses

- Find every occurrence of a surname.
- Search for a town, cemetery, church, or repository.
- Find a date or record type.
- Locate notes containing an unresolved phrase such as `needs citation`.
- Search note properties, folders, or tags.

Simple examples

```
Beattie
```

```
"Carroll County, Missouri"
```

```
path:"04 Sources"
```

Learn online: [Search](#)

Backlinks

Backlinks show which other notes link to the note currently open.

Genealogy uses

- See every source that mentions an ancestor.
- Find all family, place, and research-log notes connected to a person.
- Discover an earlier note that mentions the same witness or neighbor.
- Locate unlinked mentions of a name.

Backlinks answer the question:

| Where else have I mentioned this person, place, source, or research question?

Learn online: [Backlinks](#)

Outgoing Links

Outgoing Links shows the links contained in the note currently open.

Genealogy uses

- Review the people, places, and sources linked from an ancestor note.
- Detect links to notes that have not been created yet.
- Check whether a source note connects to all relevant people.

Learn online: [Outgoing Links](#)

Templates

Templates inserts a reusable note structure into the note currently open.

Useful genealogy templates

- Person or ancestor note
- Family note
- Place note
- Source note
- Research log
- Research question
- Timeline
- AI analysis

Templates help keep similar notes consistent. A template can also insert the current date, time, or note title.

Learn online: [Templates](#)

File Recovery

File Recovery keeps snapshots that may help restore earlier note content.

Genealogy uses

- Recover text deleted accidentally.
- Restore an earlier version of a research note.
- Recover a note after an unwanted edit.

Warning

File Recovery is helpful, but it is not a complete backup system. Keep a separate backup of the entire vault.

Learn online: [File Recovery](#)

Useful after learning the basics

Properties

Properties store consistent pieces of information at the beginning of a note.

Possible person properties

```
---
type: person
surname: Beattie
birth_date:
death_date:
research_status: active
---
```

Possible source properties

```
---
type: source
record_type: census
record_date: 1910
repository:
reviewed: false
---
```

Genealogy uses

- Sort notes by surname, date, place, or record type.
- Mark sources as reviewed or awaiting transcription.
- Identify people with missing birth or death information.
- Supply structured information to Bases.

Start with only a few properties whose purpose is clear.

Learn online: [Properties](#)

Bases

Bases creates table-like and other structured views from notes and their properties.

Genealogy uses

- Display all people in a project.
- List sources awaiting review.
- Show open research questions by family.
- Filter records by place or record type.
- Sort research logs by date.
- Create a map view when the Obsidian-maintained Maps extension is installed later.

Bases can provide many reports that previously required the more technical Dataview community plugin.

Learn online: [Introduction to Bases](#)

Canvas

Canvas is an infinite visual workspace for arranging and connecting notes, text cards, images, PDFs, media, and webpages.

Genealogy uses

- Diagram a complicated family.
- Arrange evidence around a research question.
- Compare conflicting records.
- Create a FAN Club diagram of friends, associates, and neighbors.
- Illustrate a migration path.
- Prepare a visual case summary.

Canvas is manually arranged. It shows the relationships you choose to explain.

Learn online: [Canvas documentation](#) and [Canvas tips and demonstrations](#)

Graph View

Graph View visualizes links among notes in the vault. Local Graph displays notes surrounding the note currently open.

Genealogy uses

- View a cluster of people, places, and sources.
- Notice an ancestor with few connected sources.

- Explore connections among associates and neighbors.
- Present the growth of a connected research project.

The graph is not a family-tree chart and does not prove relationships. It reflects links that exist in your notes.

Learn online: [Graph View](#)

Bookmarks

Bookmarks provides quick access to frequently used notes, folders, searches, headings, and other items.

Genealogy uses

- Bookmark the active family project.
- Save an important brick-wall research question.
- Bookmark a frequently used research log.
- Save a useful search.
- Keep a repository or locality guide readily available.

Learn online: [Bookmarks](#)

Page Preview

Page Preview lets you preview another note by hovering over its link.

Genealogy uses

- Quickly check a person's vital information without leaving the current note.
- Preview a source while working in a research log.
- Check a place or repository note while reading an ancestor note.

Learn online: [Page Preview](#)

Quick Switcher

Quick Switcher finds and opens notes using the keyboard.

Genealogy uses

- Jump quickly to an ancestor.
- Open a place or source note without browsing folders.
- Create a note when the desired filename does not exist.

Use **Command-O** on Mac or **Control-O** on Windows and Linux.

Learn online: [Quick Switcher](#)

Outline

Outline displays the headings in the note currently open.

Genealogy uses

- Navigate a long ancestor biography.
- Move among sections of a research report.
- Find a year or record group in a lengthy timeline.
- Navigate a locality or repository guide.

Learn online: [Outline](#)

Workspaces

Workspaces saves arrangements of open tabs and sidebars.

Genealogy uses

- Save a layout for record analysis.
- Save another layout for writing a family narrative.
- Keep an ancestor note, source note, PDF, and Backlinks panel arranged together.

Learn online: [Workspaces](#)

Specialized built-in tools

Audio Recorder

Audio Recorder records audio directly into the vault.

Possible uses include recording personal research observations or an interview when the participants have given informed permission.

Consider privacy, consent, file size, transcription, and long-term preservation before recording interviews.

Learn online: [Audio Recorder](#)

Note Composer

Note Composer can merge notes or extract part of a note into a separate file.

Genealogy uses

- Extract one ancestor from a long family note.
- Split a large research report into separate evidence and research-plan notes.
- Merge duplicate notes carefully.

Always keep a backup before making large structural changes.

Learn online: [Note Composer](#)

Daily Notes

Daily Notes creates a note for the current date.

Genealogy uses

- Keep a daily research journal.
- Record searches performed that day.
- Note correspondence with archives or relatives.
- Link daily work to ancestors, sources, and projects.

A dedicated Research Log template may be easier for beginners, but Daily Notes can become useful for regular researchers.

Learn online: [Daily Notes](#)

Web Viewer

Web Viewer opens webpages within Obsidian.

It can be convenient for viewing archive catalogs or reference pages beside research notes. Website behavior and sign-in support can vary.

Learn online: [Web Viewer](#)

Suggested beginner configuration

Enable and learn first

- File Explorer
- Search
- Backlinks
- Outgoing Links
- Templates
- File Recovery
- Page Preview
- Quick Switcher

Explore after creating several notes

- Properties
- Bases
- Canvas
- Graph View
- Bookmarks
- Outline
- Workspaces

Use only when a particular need arises

- Audio Recorder
 - Daily Notes
 - Note Composer
 - Web Viewer
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Important distinctions

Core plugin versus community plugin

- A **core plugin** is built and supported by the Obsidian team.
- A **community plugin** is created by a third party.
- Core plugins are included with Obsidian and can be managed under **Settings** → **Core plugins**.
- Community plugins must be installed separately and should be evaluated for maintenance, security, privacy, and long-term compatibility.

Sync versus backup

Synchronizing a vault between devices does not replace a backup. A deletion or unwanted change may synchronize to every device.

Maintain a separate, recoverable backup of the entire vault.

Learn online: [Back up your Obsidian files](#)

General learning resources

- [Official Obsidian Help](#)
- [Getting started with Obsidian](#)
- [Core plugins](#)
- [Workspace and interface](#)
- [Basic formatting syntax](#)
- [Internal links](#)
- [Attachments](#)
- [Obsidian community forum](#)

Note

Features and interface details can change. Consult the official documentation for the version of Obsidian installed on your computer.

Recommended first exercise

1. Create one person note from a template.
2. Create one source note.
3. Link the source to the person.
4. Open Backlinks on the person note.
5. Search for the person's surname.
6. Make a backup copy of the vault.

You now have a small but functional genealogy research system using only Obsidian's built-in tools.